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MP launches photo petition in Parliament

- By Chris Cheesman Wednesday, 12 March 2008
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Austin Mitchell MP (pictured) is canvassing the support of fellow politicians following growing reports of police stopping innocent photography enthusiasts taking pictures in public areas.

The move comes just weeks after police launched a new nationwide anti-terrorism publicity campaign, alerting the public to people with cameras behaving suspiciously.

Mitchell, the MP for Great Grimsby, asked *Amateur Photographer* magazine to supply details of cases it has received over the past few months before drawing up the petition, which was tabled in the House of Commons on 11 March.

Commenting on the current climate Mitchell told us: 'It's all daft.'

He cite Powered by Po.st Support Officers as among the worst offenders.

Mitchell stressed that taking pictures in public areas is ‘perfectly legal’ and urged the Home Office and the Association of Chief Police Officers (ACPO) to agree on a ‘photography code’ to be used by police officers ‘on the ground’.

Such a code, states the petition, should set out the ‘public’s right to photograph public places thus allowing photographers to enjoy their hobby without officious interference or unjustified suspicion’.

Austin Mitchell, a keen photographer, chairs the Parliamentary All-Party Photography Group.

An EDM is a formal motion that allows MPs to express and publicise their opinions on given matters and gives fellow politicians the opportunity to support it by adding their signatures.

It is possible that an EDM is debated in the House of Commons.

Click here to read the Early Day Motion in full

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